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Director
ADP India Pvt Ltd

Certification plays a very significant role in the overall assessment of a candidate. Depending on the post a candidate is being considered for—say for a system administrator post—an MCSE or CCNE certification carries considerable weight.

Certification recognises and validates skills, and helps the industry standardise evaluation criteria: an MCSE from India or the US identifies similar competencies.

In a country such as India with half a million MCAs and BEs, the industry is in no position to absorb all of them. Only 10 to 15 per cent are directly employable. Certification can be a differentiating factor. It helps a generalist become a specialist.

A B.E. or B.Tech. graduate can decide the line of work he wants to pursue and then choose a certification course accordingly. The ADP portal offers training for almost every certification currently available, including some in areas such as payroll processing and project management.

As far as recruitment of freshers to ADP is concerned, our entry test evaluates basic quantitative, logical and programming capability. According to the demand and supply situation, we may not be rigid about a candidate's aggregate percentage, provided the candidate demonstrates the required competence. In such a case, certification may give him an added advantage.

COURSES A VALUE-ADD?



Ashok Reddy
Executive vice president
HR and corporate affairs
Infotech Enterprises Ltd

Certification does not play a primary role in the recruitment process, especially in the case of freshers. Infotech recruits only graduates who have secured first class, that is, above 65 per cent aggregate. Such candidates are then put through an entrance exam, a group discussion, and two levels of interviews. Apart from this, their final year project is of importance. Even if it's a dummy project, what the candidate has learnt from it is important. Following all these considerations are soft skills such as communication and team dynamics.

It's only after these criteria that certification comes into consideration. Other parameters being the same, a certified candidate will probably stand a better chance. However, in the case of freshers, our in-house training is good enough to impart the necessary job skills.

Some clients do mention a preference for a particular number of certified candidates in a project, but there are often experienced members in the team with the required profile.

Of the 300 freshers we recruited in 2006, very few possess any certification.



Nitya Nivali
Senior manager - HR
Progress Software

A graduation in engineering provides the necessary background for a fresher. Gaps in specific skills are bridged by on-the-job and internal training. In the case of experienced candidates, yes, a certification could be an added advantage—for example, an MCSE or CCNE for a systems position, or an OCP for a database position. But we certainly don't consider these a substitute for relevant experience.

For a fresher, certification can perhaps guarantee an interview, but not a job. His concepts as proved by his academics and performance in the interview are more relevant. Let's say we're recruiting a Java resource; once basic proficiency is established, the candidate's attitude and willingness to learn is perhaps more important than a Java certification. If he doesn't have one, our internal training process will more than make up for it.

Certification is probably the last thing one would consider in the process of recruiting a fresher, and it's definitely not a make-good for average or poor academics. However, after three to four years of experience, an employee can consider certifications such as PMP (Project Management Professional) to move into a Project Manager post.

As told to Philip Malayil (philip_malayil@thinkdigit.com)